

How the exam is written

The published format, the anatomy of a question, how distractors are built, and how to spend 130 minutes.

What the exam guide actually says

FACT	VALUE
Questions	65 in total
Scored	50. The other 15 are unscored and not identified
Time	130 minutes
Score range	100 to 1,000, with 720 to pass
Scoring model	Compensatory. You do not need to pass each domain
Response types	Multiple choice, and multiple response. Only these two
Guessing	No penalty. An unanswered question is simply wrong

ON THE EXAM

Verified against the published exam guide. The last row means you should never leave a question blank.

Registration and policy

ITEM	WHAT APPLIES
Delivery	Pearson VUE. Test centre, or online proctored
Fee	150 US dollars for an associate exam
ESL accommodation	An extra 30 minutes if English is not your first language
Retake	14 calendar days after a failure. No limit on attempts
After passing	You cannot re-sit the same exam for two years
Validity	Three years

ON THE EXAM

The ESL accommodation must be requested in your certification account before you schedule. It is not offered at booking.

What compensatory scoring means for you

- ◆ You need **seven hundred and twenty overall**, not in each domain.
- ◆ A **weak domain can be carried** by strength elsewhere.
- ◆ **Domain four is eighteen percent**, which is about nine scored questions.
- ◆ **Writing it off entirely** means starting from eighty two percent, needing most of the rest.
- ◆ **Fifty scored questions** means each one is worth two percent of the total.

ON THE EXAM

Fifty scored questions and a 720 pass mark. The arithmetic is tighter than the compensatory model makes it sound.

A question has three parts, and they are almost always in the **same order**.

The three parts, and what each is for

PART	WHAT IT DOES
The situation	Context. Names the technologies in play and the current design
The problem	What is wrong, or what must now be possible
The constraint	What the solution may not do. Often a stated refusal
The qualifier	Which of several correct answers is wanted
The question	Usually one sentence, and rarely the interesting part

ON THE EXAM

The constraint and the qualifier decide most questions. They are usually the last two sentences before the options.

Reading in the right order

- ◆ **Read the actual question first**, the sentence with the question mark.
- ◆ **Then read the scenario** knowing what you are looking for.
- ◆ **Note the constraint and the qualifier** before you look at any option.
- ◆ **Then read the options**, eliminating against what you noted.
- ◆ **Reading options first** forms an opinion you then defend rather than test.

ON THE EXAM

Reading the question before the scenario means you read three hundred words with a purpose rather than as narrative.

Skimming a long scenario safely

- ◆ **Names of technologies** matter. Kafka, MongoDB, Hive, SFTP each decide something.
- ◆ **Numbers** matter. They are usually there to cross a limit.
- ◆ **Negations** matter most. Cannot, will not, does not want, must not.
- ◆ **Industry and company size** rarely matter. A retailer and a bank read the same.
- ◆ **The current architecture** is often context, not constraint.

ON THE EXAM

Three things to read carefully and two to move past quickly. That is what makes a 200-word scenario take 40 seconds.

There are about **six ways** to make a wrong answer look right, and this exam uses all of them.

How a wrong answer is built

PATTERN	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Right answer, wrong question	Concurrency scaling for a slow query, not a queued one
Capacity for a non-capacity problem	More workers for skew, more nodes for a single input file
Breaks a stated constraint	A rewrite, where the question said the application cannot change
Solves half the requirement	Cheaper storage that fails the latency the question stated
Automating a bad design	A script that maintains fourteen views instead of removing them
Asserting something false	A service cannot do something it can, or can do something it cannot

ON THE EXAM

The last row is the fastest elimination. If an option claims a capability that does not exist, it is gone in seconds.

Tells in the wording of an option

- ◆ **Absolutes.** Always, never, all, only. Rarely true of a real service.
- ◆ **A capability stated too broadly.** "Handles any workload" is marketing, not a fact.
- ◆ **Two options differing in one word** are the pair being tested.
- ◆ **An option naming a specific feature** is often the intended answer, because it is precise.
- ◆ **An option that solves nothing stated** is there to catch pattern matching on a service name.

ON THE EXAM

The third point is the most useful. When two options are nearly identical, that one differing word is the whole question.

The most seductive distractor

- ◆ It is usually the answer an experienced engineer would give in real life.
- ◆ Building a Glue job where a managed feature already exists.
- ◆ Writing custom validation where Glue Data Quality does it declaratively.
- ◆ A second redacted copy where a column grant serves both audiences.
- ◆ Experience is an asset, and it makes you reach for what you have built before.

ON THE EXAM

The exam rewards the managed option more consistently than production experience does. That is a bias to correct for.

Where this course's scenarios came from

- ◆ **Eighty worked scenarios** across twenty teaching modules.
- ◆ **Every one names the deciding sentence** in its signal callout.
- ◆ **Every wrong option has a reason**, not just a cross.
- ◆ **Several come in pairs**, where one changed constraint moves the answer.
- ◆ **None reproduces a real exam question**. They are built from the exam guide.

ON THE EXAM

If you reread nothing else, reread the signal callouts. They are the deciding sentence in eighty different questions.

Read this question for its structure rather than its content. A company ingests clickstream data into Amazon S3. Analysts query it with Amazon Athena and complain about cost. The data is uncompressed JSON in a single prefix. The team has no capacity to build and maintain a new pipeline, and the change must not alter how analysts write their queries. The question then asks for the MOST cost-effective approach.

Which sentence in that scenario eliminates the most options?

- ☐ A The data is uncompressed JSON in a single prefix
- ☐ B The team has no capacity to build and maintain a new pipeline
- ☐ C Analysts query it with Amazon Athena
- ☐ D The change must not alter how analysts write their queries

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which sentence in that scenario eliminates the most options?

- A

 Uncompressed JSON, single prefix
Diagnostic. It tells you what is wrong, which points at the answer rather than eliminating options.
- B

 No capacity to build and maintain a pipeline
A stated refusal. It removes every option involving a new job, cluster or scheduled component, whatever their merits.
- C

 Analysts use Athena
Context. It tells you the billing model is bytes scanned, which shapes the answer without eliminating much.
- D

 Queries must not change
A real constraint, removing options that move the data to another engine. Fewer options than B removes.

THE SIGNAL

Constraints eliminate. Symptoms point. Both matter, and only one of them shortens the list of options.

Multiple response questions

- ◆ **Two or more correct from five or more options.** The question says how many.
- ◆ **No partial credit.** Three of four correct scores the same as zero.
- ◆ **Eliminate first**, because five options usually contain two obvious wrongs.
- ◆ **Look for a pair that works together**, because correct answers often combine.
- ◆ **Do not select more than asked**, even if a third looks right.

ON THE EXAM

Select two often means one control and one detection, or one fix and one prevention.
The pair complements.

A multiple response question describes a Glue job that succeeds nightly while producing totals that are two percent low. The company wants to detect this class of problem in future and to stop bad data reaching the warehouse.

It asks you to select TWO answers from five options.

Which pair of answers is the shape to look for?

- ☐ A Two options that both add capacity, because the job may be under-resourced
- ☐ B One that detects the problem and one that prevents bad data continuing downstream
- ☐ C Two options that both improve monitoring, since the problem went unnoticed
- ☐ D Any two options that are individually correct, in any combination

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which pair of answers is the shape to look for?

- A

 Two capacity options
Nothing failed and nothing was slow. Capacity answers neither half of a correctness requirement.
- B

 One detects, one prevents
The question states two requirements. The pair almost always maps onto them, one each.
- C

 Two monitoring options
Covers detection twice and leaves prevention unaddressed, so half the stated requirement fails.
- D

 Any two correct options
Individually correct is not the test. The pair has to cover the requirement between them.

THE SIGNAL

Two stated requirements usually means one answer each. Count the requirements before choosing.

When two options both look right

- ◆ **Reread the qualifier.** It exists precisely to separate two correct answers.
- ◆ **Ask which one the constraint forbids**, rather than which is better engineering.
- ◆ **Ask which solves the whole requirement**, because one often covers half.
- ◆ **Prefer the managed option** when overhead is the qualifier.
- ◆ **Do not choose on elegance.** The exam is not marking your architecture.

ON THE EXAM

Two plausible options is the normal state of a good question, not a sign you have misunderstood it.

Managing a hundred and thirty minutes

- ◆ **Two minutes a question**, and some questions take thirty seconds.
- ◆ **Bank the easy ones fast**, which buys time for the long scenarios.
- ◆ **Never spend five minutes on one question**. Answer it, flag it, move on.
- ◆ **Always record an answer before flagging**, in case you never return.
- ◆ **Aim to reach question sixty five** with fifteen minutes remaining.

ON THE EXAM

The fourth point is the one people get wrong. Flagging without answering risks a blank if time runs out.

Fatigue is a real factor

- ◆ Question fifty is harder than question five, at identical difficulty.
- ◆ Bank easy questions early while your reading is sharpest.
- ◆ Long scenarios late are where misreadings happen. Slow down deliberately.
- ◆ A test centre allows a break, though the clock does not stop.
- ◆ Online proctored has stricter rules. Know them before the day.

ON THE EXAM

Most wrong answers in the last twenty questions are misreadings rather than gaps in knowledge.

Using elimination properly

- ◆ **Eliminate on facts first.** An impossible claim goes immediately.
- ◆ **Then on stated constraints,** which usually removes one or two more.
- ◆ **Then on the qualifier,** which separates what remains.
- ◆ **Comparing all four on merit** is the slowest possible method.
- ◆ **Two eliminated means fifty percent** even if the last step defeats you.

ON THE EXAM

Even a failed question is worth eliminating on, because a coin flip between two beats a guess between four.

When to change an answer

- ◆ **Change it if you have found a fact you missed**, a constraint or a limit.
- ◆ **Change it if a later question reminded you** of how something actually works.
- ◆ **Do not change it on a feeling** that the other option looks better now.
- ◆ **Reread the constraint**, not the options, when reviewing.
- ◆ **Do not reread everything**. Review the flagged questions and stop.

ON THE EXAM

On review, go back to the scenario rather than the options. The sentence you skimmed is usually the answer.

You are at question forty eight with thirty five minutes remaining. You have six questions flagged for review. Question forty eight describes a complex multi-account governance scenario and you are torn between two options after three minutes of reading.

You are not confident about either.

What is the best use of the next thirty seconds?

- ☐ A Keep working on question forty eight until you are confident
- ☐ B Select your better guess, flag it, and move to question forty nine
- ☐ C Leave it blank, flag it, and return at the end with fresh eyes
- ☐ D Go back and review the six flagged questions first

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best use of the next thirty seconds?

- A

 Keep working until confident
Three minutes already spent on a two-minute question. Seventeen questions remain and confidence may not arrive.
- B

 Guess, flag, move on
Converts a possible blank into a real chance, protects the seventeen unseen questions, and keeps the option to return.
- C

 Leave blank and flag
Right to move on, and a blank scores zero if time runs out. Guessing costs two seconds and nothing else.
- D

 Review the flagged six now
Reviewing answered questions while seventeen unseen ones remain. Unseen questions are worth more than reconsidered ones.

THE SIGNAL

An unseen question is worth more than a reconsidered one. Reach the end before you go back.

What the score report tells you

- ◆ **Pass or fail is shown on screen** at the end for an associate exam.
- ◆ **The full report arrives** in your certification account within a few days.
- ◆ **Section-level feedback** classifies your performance per domain.
- ◆ **It is not a percentage per domain**, and AWS advises caution interpreting it.
- ◆ **Use it to direct a retake**, not to reconstruct which questions you missed.

ON THE EXAM

The exam guide itself says to use caution when interpreting section-level feedback. The samples per domain are small.

What the exam guide expects you to know

- ◆ **Two to three years of data engineering**, and one to two years of AWS.
- ◆ **Git commands** for source control, at a vocabulary level.
- ◆ **How to structure and run SQL queries** on AWS services.
- ◆ **General concepts of vectors**, added in the latest revision.
- ◆ **Explicitly out of scope**: language syntax, ML training, business conclusions.

ON THE EXAM

The last row is a gift. You will not be asked to read code, train a model, or interpret what the data means for the business.

What the exam does not test

- ◆ **Prices.** No question needs a dollar figure, and they change.
- ◆ **Console click paths.** Where a setting lives in the interface.
- ◆ **Exact syntax** of a policy, a DQDL rule or a Spark transformation.
- ◆ **Service limits you cannot reason about**, beyond the well-known ones.
- ◆ **It does test the limits that change an answer**, like fifteen minutes or one hundred partitions.

ON THE EXAM

The distinction on the last row is the useful one. Memorise limits that make an option impossible, not trivia.

Where the questions come from

DOMAIN	SHARE, AND ROUGHLY HOW MANY SCORED QUESTIONS
1. Data Ingestion and Transformation	34 percent, around 17 of 50
2. Data Store Management	26 percent, around 13
3. Data Operations and Support	22 percent, around 11
4. Data Security and Governance	18 percent, around 9

ON THE EXAM

Domain 1 is a third of the exam on its own. Modules 2 through 7 cover it, and they are the longest in this course.

You have finished a practice exam and scored sixty eight percent. Your section feedback shows you are strongest in Domain 1 and weakest in Domain 4, where you got roughly half the questions right.

You have two weeks before the exam and about an hour a day to study.

What is the most effective use of that time?

- ☐ A Revise Domain 1 further, since it is a third of the exam and you are already strong
- ☐ B Focus on Domain 4, and review the specific questions you got wrong across all domains
- ☐ C Take another four practice exams to build familiarity
- ☐ D Rewatch the entire course from the beginning

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the most effective use of that time?

- A

 More Domain 1
Improving a strength has the least headroom. Going from strong to slightly stronger gains very little.
- B

 Domain 4, plus reviewing every wrong answer
Nine questions where you score half. That is the largest available gain, and wrong answers are diagnostic.
- C

 Four more practice exams
Measures readiness repeatedly without changing it. Taking a test is not the same as learning from one.
- D

 Rewatch everything
Fourteen hours of study time spent proportionally, including on material you have already demonstrated.

THE SIGNAL

Reviewing the questions you got wrong is worth more than answering new ones. That is where the information is.

The week before

- ◆ **Reread the confusion pairs module**, particularly the words that decide.
- ◆ **Reread the availability warnings**, which module twenty three collects.
- ◆ **Take a practice exam under time**, to rehearse the pacing rather than the content.
- ◆ **Review every wrong answer** until you can say why the right one is right.
- ◆ **Do not learn new services in the final week**. Consolidate what you have.

ON THE EXAM

The fourth point is the whole method. Being able to explain why the wrong answer is wrong is the actual skill.

The night before

- ◆ **Do not learn anything new.** Nothing absorbed at midnight survives to the morning.
- ◆ **Reread the words that decide,** from module twenty one.
- ◆ **Reread the availability warnings** from module twenty three.
- ◆ **Check the logistics.** Identification, the room, the software, the time.
- ◆ **Sleep.** Two hours of reading buys less than two hours of rest.

ON THE EXAM

Two hours of dense reading is a stamina exercise. Being tired costs more marks than one more service would gain.

On the day

- ◆ **Read the question first**, then the scenario, then the options.
- ◆ **Find the constraint and the qualifier** before eliminating.
- ◆ **Answer everything**, even if only to flag and return.
- ◆ **Reach the end before you review**, because unseen questions are worth more.
- ◆ **Trust the elimination**, not the option that feels most like what you would build.

ON THE EXAM

Next: the December 2025 revision gap. What changed, and where older study material is now wrong.